SENIORS AUDIT

Your Turning 65 Medicare Enrollment Action Planner

The exact dates, decisions, and hidden deadlines that determine what Medicare costs you for life

Version 2026.1 • Last reviewed September 2026

Print-friendly in full color or black & white • 23 pages, US Letter

seniorsaudit.com

Independent. No insurance sales. No lead generation. Sourced from Medicare.gov, CMS, and KFF.

Contents

What This Planner Helps You Decide....3
Before You Begin....5
Step 1 — Find Your Initial Enrollment Period (IEP)....6
Step 2 — Still Working? Here's the Rule That Actually Matters....8
Step 3 — What Waiting Actually Costs (2026 Numbers)....10
Step 4 — Choosing Your Coverage Path....12
Step 5 — Don't Forget Part D....13
Step 6 — Your Medigap Open Enrollment....14
Step 7 — Build Your Personal Timeline....16
Your Decision Worksheet....17
Action Checklist — In Order....18
Common Mistakes to Avoid....19
Already Past a Deadline? Do This First....20
Questions to Ask....21
How to Read the Confidence Markers....22
Sources & Update Information....23

Short on time? Read Step 6 (the Medigap window) — it's the one deadline in this planner that never comes back around.

What This Planner Helps You Decide

This planner answers three questions that determine what Medicare costs you for the rest of your life: When exactly do I need to enroll? What happens if I wait? And is there a one-time window closing that I don't know about?

Most Medicare guides explain what the parts are. Very few explain the deadlines that turn a $0 decision into a permanent monthly penalty — or a one-time opportunity that never comes back around. This planner focuses entirely on timing and decisions, not on general Medicare education.

> The single most expensive mistake in this entire planner is in Step 6: the Medigap guaranteed-issue window. It only happens once, it's easy to miss, and almost no one warns you about it clearly. Read that section even if you skip everything else.

Who this is for

- You're turning 65 within the next 12 months
- You're already 65+ and unsure if you missed a deadline
- You're helping a parent navigate this right now

Who should also talk to a professional

- You have complex retiree health coverage from a former employer
- You have a disability-based Medicare eligibility (under 65)

- You have a pre-existing health condition and are considering Medigap
- You live in a state with unusual Medigap rules (see Step 6)

Before You Begin

Gather these before starting — it makes every worksheet in this planner exact instead of approximate:

- ☐ Your exact birth date
- ☐ Whether you (or your spouse) currently have employer group health coverage, and how many employees that employer has
- ☐ Whether you've already started Social Security retirement benefits (this affects automatic enrollment)
- ☐ Your Modified Adjusted Gross Income (MAGI) from 2 years ago, if you want to check IRMAA exposure

If you're already collecting Social Security retirement benefits, you are automatically enrolled in Medicare Part A and Part B starting the month you turn 65 — you don't need to do anything, but you CAN'T decline Part B without extra paperwork if you want to delay it. Check your mail for a red, white, and blue Medicare card around 3 months before your 65th birthday.

STEP 1 OF 7

Step 1 — Find Your Initial Enrollment Period (IEP)

Your Initial Enrollment Period (IEP) is a 7-month window built around your 65th birthday. It is your first, and usually best, chance to enroll without any penalty.

Window	Timing
Starts	3 months before the month you turn 65
Includes	The month you turn 65
Ends	3 months after the month you turn 65
Total length	7 months

My 65th birthday month: _____

My IEP starts (3 months before): _____

My IEP ends (3 months after): _____

Coverage start date depends on exactly when in this window you enroll. If you enroll in the 3 months before your birthday month, coverage typically starts the month you turn 65. If you enroll during or after your birthday month, coverage starts the first day of the following month. Confirm your exact effective date with the free Seniors Audit Medicare Effective Date Calculator: seniorsaudit.com/tools/medicare-effective-date-calculator

⚡ Pro tip most people don't know

If your birthday is on the 1st of the month, Social Security treats you as turning 65 the PREVIOUS month for Medicare purposes — which shifts your entire 7-month window one month earlier. If you were born on the 1st, double-check your window using the calculator above rather than counting from your actual birth date.

STEP 2 OF 7

Step 2 — Still Working? Here's the Rule That Actually Matters

If you (or your spouse) are still working and have health coverage through a current employer, you may be able to delay Medicare Part B without any penalty — but only if the employer meets a specific size rule.

Employer size	Can you delay Part B penalty-free?
20 or more employees	Yes — employer coverage is primary. You can delay Part B and enroll later using a Special Enrollment Period.
Fewer than 20 employees	Usually no — Medicare typically becomes primary at 65 regardless, so most people should enroll in Part A and B on time.

COMMON MISTAKE: COBRA coverage, retiree health coverage from a former employer, and individual marketplace plans do NOT count as “current employer coverage.” They do not qualify you for a Special Enrollment Period, and they will NOT protect you from the Part B late enrollment penalty. This is one of the most common and expensive mistakes people make at 65.

If you qualify to delay

You get an 8-month Special Enrollment Period (SEP) to sign up for Part B without penalty, starting the month AFTER your employment or employer coverage ends — whichever comes first.

Does my employer have 20+ employees? ☐ Yes ☐ No ☐ Not sure — will check

My SEP would start (if applicable):

_____

STEP 3 OF 7

Step 3 — What Waiting Actually Costs (2026 Numbers)

If you don't qualify for a Special Enrollment Period and miss your Initial Enrollment Period anyway, here's exactly what each part costs you — using this year's real figures.

Part A penalty (only applies if you don't get it free)

Situation	2026 monthly cost
Premium-free Part A (40+ work quarters)	$0 — no penalty risk
Part A premium (30–39 quarters)	$311/month, +10% penalty if late, for twice the years you waited
Part A premium (fewer than 30 quarters)	$565/month, +10% penalty if late, for twice the years you waited

Part B penalty — this is the one that hurts most

The Part B penalty adds 10% to your premium for every full 12-month period you were eligible but didn't enroll — and you pay it for as long as you have Part B. Potentially for life.

Worked example

James turned 65 in 2024 and didn't enroll — he had no employer coverage and no other reason to delay. He finally enrolled in 2026, two full years late.

Standard Part B premium (2026): $202.90/month
Penalty: 10% × 2 years late = 20%
Extra cost: $202.90 × 0.20 = $40.58/month, permanently
His real monthly Part B cost: $243.48/month, for life — an extra $486.96 every year, forever, because of a decision made once.

Part D penalty

If you go 63 days or more without Medicare drug coverage or other “creditable” coverage (coverage as good as Medicare's), you'll owe 1% of the national base beneficiary premium ($38.99 in 2026) for every month you went without it — permanently added to your Part D premium.

Months I might have gone (or could go) without coverage: _____

Estimated Part D penalty (months × 1% × $38.99): _____

Sources: Medicare.gov/basics/costs/medicare-costs/avoid-penalties, CMS 2026 fact sheet

STEP 4 OF 7

Step 4 — Choosing Your Coverage Path

This is the biggest decision in this planner, and there's no universally right answer — it depends on your health needs, travel habits, budget, and how much you value flexibility versus predictability.

	Original Medicare + Medigap + Part D	Medicare Advantage (Part C)
Doctor choice	Any doctor who accepts Medicare, nationwide	Usually a limited network, often local
Monthly cost	Higher (Medigap premium + Part D)	Often lower or $0 premium, but more cost-sharing when you use care
Predictability	Very predictable costs	Costs vary more by how much care you use
Extra benefits (dental, vision, hearing)	Not included — separate coverage needed	Often included
Referrals needed	No	Often yes, for specialists

There is no “best” choice here — only a best fit for your situation. If you're unsure, the free Seniors Audit Medicare Advantage vs. Original Medicare Cost Checker can estimate your likely annual cost under each path using your own numbers: seniorsaudit.com/tools/medicare-advantage-vs-original-medicare-cost-checker

STEP 5 OF 7

Step 5 — Don't Forget Part D (Even If You Take No Medications)

This is one of the most overlooked decisions at 65. Even if you take zero prescriptions right now, going without any Part D or creditable drug coverage for 63+ days starts your Part D penalty clock — and it never resets.

⚡ FAST-ACTION TIP: If you're not sure whether you need Part D yet, the safest and fastest move is to enroll in the lowest-cost stand-alone Part D plan available in your area during your IEP — even a $0–$10/month basic plan protects you from the penalty clock permanently, regardless of whether you ever fill a prescription on it.

2026 Part D figures:

- Part D deductible cap: $615 (no plan can charge more)
- Part D out-of-pocket cap: $2,100 (after this, you pay $0 more for covered drugs the rest of the year)
- National base beneficiary premium (used for penalty math): $38.99

STEP 6 OF 7

Step 6 — Your Medigap Open Enrollment: A Door That Only Opens Once

If you plan to pair Original Medicare with a Medigap (Medicare Supplement) policy, there is a single 6-month window where insurance companies CANNOT deny you a policy or charge you more because of your health. It starts the first month you have Medicare Part B and are 65 or older. It happens exactly once in your life, federally, and it does not repeat.

⚠ **MISS THIS WINDOW AND: In most states, insurance companies CAN deny you a Medigap policy entirely, or charge you significantly more, based on your health history — things like a heart condition, cancer treatment, diabetes complications, or a stroke history can result in denial. This is federal law (per KFF and Medicare.gov), and very few general Medicare guides explain it clearly.**

What this means practically

Even if you're leaning toward Medicare Advantage right now, if there's any chance you might want a Medigap policy later, strongly consider whether enrolling in Medigap during this window — even a low-cost plan — is worth protecting your right to have one, before a future health change could close that door.

State exceptions worth checking

A few states (including New York and Connecticut) have their own rules that reduce or remove medical underwriting outside this window, and some states have annual “birthday rule” windows for switching plans. Check your state's exact rules at your State Health Insurance Assistance Program (SHIP) — shiphelp.org — before assuming the federal 6-month rule is your only chance.

My Part B start date: _____

My Medigap Open Enrollment window ends (start date + 6 months): _____

STEP 7 OF 7

Step 7 — Build Your Personal Timeline

Fill in your own dates based on everything calculated in Steps 1–6.

Milestone	My date
IEP starts	
IEP ends	
SEP starts (if delaying via employer coverage)	
SEP ends (8 months from SEP start)	
Medigap Open Enrollment starts (if applicable)	
Medigap Open Enrollment ends (6 months later)	
Target enrollment date	

Your Decision Worksheet

Bring together your situation into one page.

☐ I have (or my spouse has) current employer coverage from an employer with 20+ employees

☐ I've confirmed my exact IEP or SEP window using Step 1 or 2

☐ I've decided between Original Medicare and Medicare Advantage (Step 4)

☐ If choosing Original Medicare, I've enrolled in at least a basic Part D plan (Step 5)

☐ I understand my Medigap Open Enrollment window and whether it applies to me (Step 6)

☐ I've written my personal timeline (Step 7)

Weighting guide

If most of your checkmarks are complete, you're on track — proceed to the Action Checklist. If you're unsure about employer coverage size, SEP eligibility, or your Medigap window specifically, those three are the ones most likely to cost real money if guessed wrong — resolve those before your enrollment date, even if it means one phone call to Medicare (1-800-MEDICARE) or your HR department to confirm.

Action Checklist — In Order

☐ **3–4 months before IEP starts:** Confirm whether you're auto-enrolled (already collecting Social Security) or need to actively enroll

☐ **At IEP start:** Decide Original Medicare vs. Medicare Advantage (Step 4)

☐ **During IEP:** Enroll in Part A and Part B at ssa.gov/medicare or by phone

☐ **During IEP:** If choosing Original Medicare, enroll in a Part D plan — even a basic one (Step 5)

☐ **Within your 6-month Medigap window:** Shop and enroll in a Medigap policy if you want one (Step 6) — before any health change could close this door

☐ **Ongoing:** Mark your calendar for Medicare's Annual Open Enrollment (Oct 15 – Dec 7) to review your plan choice every year

☐ **If income changed significantly 2 years ago:** Check your IRMAA exposure using the free Seniors Audit IRMAA Calculator

Common Mistakes to Avoid

1. **Assuming COBRA or retiree coverage delays your deadline.** It doesn't — only current employer coverage from active work does.
2. **Skipping Part D because you take no medications.** The penalty clock starts regardless, and it's permanent.
3. **Waiting to “shop around” past your Medigap Open Enrollment window.** This window doesn't wait for you to feel ready.
4. **Assuming a small employer's health plan delays Medicare.** Under 20 employees usually does not qualify you to delay.
5. **Not checking the exact IEP window if born on the 1st of the month.** Your window shifts a full month earlier.
6. **Confusing General Enrollment Period (Jan 1 – Mar 31) with your Initial Enrollment Period.** GEP is a fallback that usually comes with penalties already attached — it's not a safety net to rely on.
7. **Not confirming your effective date before assuming coverage has started.** Use the free effective date calculator before you cancel any other coverage.

Already Past a Deadline? Do This First

If you think you may have already missed your Initial Enrollment Period or Special Enrollment Period, here's the fastest path to minimize damage:

1. **Call 1-800-MEDICARE today** and ask directly: “Have I missed my enrollment window, and do I qualify for any Special Enrollment Period exception?” Some situations (like certain disability or hardship cases) have exceptions most people don't know to ask about.
2. **Check the General Enrollment Period dates** (January 1 – March 31 each year) — this is your fallback if you've missed everything else, even though penalties may still apply.
3. **Contact a free SHIP counselor immediately** (shiphelp.org) — they can review your specific history for free and catch exceptions a general guide like this can't account for.
4. **Don't wait to “figure it out perfectly” before calling.** Every month of delay from this point is a month that can add to a permanent penalty — acting imperfectly now beats waiting for full clarity later.

Questions to Ask

☐ Given my work history, am I eligible for premium-free Part A?

☐ Does my specific employer situation qualify me for a Special Enrollment Period?

☐ Am I inside my Medigap Open Enrollment window right now?

☐ Are there state-specific protections in my state beyond the federal 6-month rule?

☐ Based on my health needs, does Original Medicare + Medigap or Medicare Advantage fit me better?

How to Read the Confidence Markers in This Planner

🟢 **Straightforward —** Applies to most people with a typical work history and no employer coverage complications.

🟡 **Review carefully —** Still working, married, or considering Medicare Advantage vs. Original Medicare.

🔴 **Professional review recommended —** Complex retiree coverage, disability-based eligibility, pre-existing conditions affecting Medigap, or already-missed deadlines.

Sources & Update Information

- Medicare Costs & How to Avoid Penalties — medicare.gov/basics/costs/medicare-costs/avoid-penalties
- Medigap Open Enrollment (“Get Ready to Buy”) — medicare.gov/health-drug-plans/medigap/ready-to-buy
- KFF: Medigap and Pre-Existing Conditions — kff.org/medicare/medigap-may-be-elusive-for-medicare-beneficiaries-with-pre-existing-conditions
- CMS 2026 Medicare Parts A & B Premiums and Deductibles Fact Sheet
- Free Medicare Effective Date Calculator — seniorsaudit.com/tools/medicare-effective-date-calculator
- Free Medicare Advantage vs. Original Medicare Cost Checker — seniorsaudit.com/tools/medicare-advantage-vs-original-medicare-cost-checker
- Free IRMAA Calculator — seniorsaudit.com/tools/medicare-irmaa-calculator
- Find a free SHIP counselor — shiphelp.org

Version: 2026.1

Last reviewed: September 2026 • Next scheduled review: January 2027 (following annual CMS premium and penalty announcements)

This planner provides educational estimates and decision support. It is not personalized legal, tax, financial, or insurance advice. Seniors Audit is independent and is not affiliated with Medicare, CMS, or the Social Security Administration. We do not sell insurance and receive no commission for any recommendation in this planner. Every free tool, calculator, form, or account referenced in this planner — including Medicare enrollment at ssa.gov/medicare, the 1-800-MEDICARE helpline, and free SHIP (State Health Insurance Assistance Program) counseling at shiphelp.org — is available directly and free from ssa.gov and medicare.gov. This planner is a paid, independent organizational resource built around that free public information, not a replacement for it.

seniorsaudit.com • Free tools, honest answers